

Yoga for Arthritis Beginners: A Safe and Gentle Starting Gui

Start yoga safely with arthritis. Beginner-friendly poses, modifications for joint pain, and how to find arthritis-friendly yoga classes in the UK.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
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*Person practicing a gentle beginner yoga pose in a bright room, arthritis-friendly exercise
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Yoga has emerged as one of the most recommended complementary therapies for arthritis, endorsed by the NHS, NICE, Arthritis UK and the Arthritis Foundation globally. Yet many people with joint pain hesitate to try yoga, fearing it requires

extreme flexibility or will worsen their symptoms. The truth is that yoga — when practised with appropriate modifications — is one of the safest and most beneficial forms of exercise for arthritis. This guide is designed specifically for beginners with arthritis, covering everything from choosing the right style to step-by-step poses you can start today.

Why Yoga Works for Arthritis

Yoga combines gentle movement, stretching, strengthening and mindfulness — addressing multiple aspects of arthritis management simultaneously. Research supports its effectiveness:

- A Johns Hopkins University randomised controlled trial found that people with rheumatoid and knee osteoarthritis who practised yoga twice weekly for 8 weeks showed significant improvements in pain, physical function and mental health compared to a control group
 - A systematic review in *Rheumatology International* concluded that yoga improves joint flexibility, muscle strength and overall well-being in arthritis patients
 - Yoga has been shown to reduce inflammatory markers (CRP, IL-6) in multiple studies, suggesting benefits beyond simply improving flexibility
 - The mindfulness component of yoga helps with pain management, sleep quality and psychological well-being
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Choosing the Right Yoga Style



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Best Styles for Arthritis

- Hatha yoga — The most accessible style. Slow-paced, holds poses for several breaths, allows time for modifications. Ideal for beginners
- Iyengar yoga — Emphasises precise alignment and uses props (blocks, straps, bolsters, chairs) extensively. Particularly suited to people with physical limitations
- Restorative yoga — Uses props to support the body in passive poses held for 5–10 minutes. Deeply relaxing and gentle on joints
- Chair yoga — All poses performed seated or using a chair for support. Perfect for people with significant mobility limitations
- Yin yoga — Slow, passive stretches held for 3–5 minutes targeting connective tissues. Good for flexibility but may need modification for inflamed joints

Styles to Approach with Caution

- Vinyasa/Flow — Fast-paced transitions between poses may be too challenging initially
 - Bikram/Hot yoga — The 40°C room temperature may seem appealing for stiff joints but can cause overheating, dizziness and may mask pain signals, leading to overexertion
 - Ashtanga — Physically demanding and follows a set sequence that may not accommodate individual limitations
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Beginner Poses for Arthritis

These poses are safe for most people with arthritis. Always listen to your body and skip any pose that causes sharp pain.

1. Mountain Pose (Tadasana)

The foundation of all standing poses. Stand with feet hip-width apart, weight evenly distributed. Lengthen your spine, roll shoulders back and down, arms relaxed at your sides. Breathe deeply for 30–60 seconds. This improves posture, body awareness and balance. Modification: hold the back of a chair for balance support.

2. Cat-Cow Stretch (Marjaryasana-Bitilasana)

Begin on hands and knees (use a folded blanket under knees for cushioning). As you inhale, drop your belly towards the floor, lift your chest and gaze forward (Cow). As you exhale, round your spine towards the ceiling, tucking chin to chest (Cat). Move slowly between the two positions 8–10 times. This gently mobilises the entire spine and is excellent for back stiffness. Modification: perform seated on a chair, placing hands on thighs.

3. Seated Forward Fold (Paschimottanasana)

Sit on the floor with legs extended (sit on a folded blanket if hamstrings are tight). Inhale and lengthen your spine. Exhale and hinge forward from the hips, reaching towards your feet. Only go as far as comfortable — use a yoga strap around your feet if you can't reach. Hold for 30 seconds. This stretches hamstrings, calves and the lower back.

4. Warrior II (Virabhadrasana II)

Stand with feet wide apart (about 3–4 feet). Turn your right foot out 90 degrees and left foot slightly in. Bend your right knee over your ankle (don't let it go past your toes). Extend arms

out to the sides at shoulder height. Look over your right hand. Hold for 15–30 seconds, then switch sides. Strengthens legs, opens hips and improves balance. Modification: reduce the depth of the knee bend or practise against a wall for support.

5. Bridge Pose (Setu Bandhasana)

Lie on your back with knees bent, feet flat on the floor hip-width apart. Press through your feet and lift your hips towards the ceiling. Hold for 15–30 seconds. Lower slowly. Repeat 3 times. Strengthens glutes, hamstrings and lower back. Good for hip and knee arthritis. Modification: place a yoga block under your sacrum for a supported bridge.

6. Child's Pose (Balasana)

Kneel on the floor, sit back on your heels, then fold forward with arms extended in front. Rest your forehead on the floor (or a pillow). Hold for 30–60 seconds. A resting pose that gently stretches hips, thighs and back. Modification: place a bolster or pillows under your torso for support, or keep your knees wider apart.

Essential Tips for Practising Yoga with Arthritis



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- Use props freely — Blocks, straps, bolsters, blankets and chairs are not signs of weakness — they're tools for safe, effective practice
- Warm up first — Start with gentle movements (Cat-Cow, wrist circles, ankle rolls) before attempting deeper poses
- Modify without guilt — Every pose has modifications. A smaller range of motion done safely is always better than pushing into pain
- Breathe — Focus on slow, deep breathing throughout. Never hold your breath during a pose
- Respect your limits today — Your range and tolerance will vary day to day. What felt fine yesterday might not work today, and that's completely normal

- Avoid hyperextension — Don't lock out your knees or elbows. Keep a micro-bend in joints
 - Skip inversions initially — Poses like headstand or shoulder stand put significant pressure on joints and should only be attempted with expert guidance
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Finding Arthritis-Friendly Yoga in the UK

- NHS Exercise on Prescription — Some areas offer yoga as part of exercise referral schemes
 - Arthritis UK — Provides information about arthritis-friendly exercise classes across the UK
 - British Wheel of Yoga (bwy.org.uk) — The governing body for yoga in England. Search for qualified teachers near you
 - Yoga for Arthritis (arthritis.yoga) — An evidence-based programme developed by researchers at Johns Hopkins
 - YouTube — Free classes from channels like 'Yoga with Adriene' (search 'yoga for arthritis' or 'gentle yoga') provide accessible home practice
 - Local leisure centres and community halls — Many offer gentle or chair yoga classes at affordable rates
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Building a Sustainable Practice

Start with just 10–15 minutes, 2–3 times per week. As your confidence and comfort grow, gradually extend to 20–30 minute sessions. Many arthritis patients find that a daily 15-minute practice provides more consistent benefits than occasional longer sessions. Keep a simple log of how you feel before and after each session — most people notice improvements in mood and stiffness within the first two weeks, with meaningful changes in pain and function after 6–8 weeks of regular practice.

Yoga is a journey, not a destination. There is no perfect pose — there is only the pose that works for your body today. Our virtual assistant can suggest specific yoga poses for your affected joints.

This article is for general information only. Consult your GP or physiotherapist before starting yoga, particularly if you have severe or unstable joint disease.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about yoga for arthritis beginners: a safe and gentle starting gui?

Short answer: Yoga is beneficial for arthritis as it combines gentle movement, stretching, strengthening, and mindfulness, helping manage various aspects of the condition. Recommended styles for beginners include Hatha, Iyengar, Restorative, and Chair yoga, which are adaptable and use props to support precise alignment and reduce joint strain. Always listen to your body and modify poses to avoid pain.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk